



LITTLE MINDS, BIG FUTURES · WILLIAMSON COUNTY, TN

Is My Child Ready for Kindergarten?

A 25-Point Readiness Checklist · By Leslie Dykstra, Certified Early Childhood Specialist

Kindergarten readiness isn't just knowing the alphabet — it's academic, physical, social, and emotional, and it looks different for every child. Work through this slowly. Don't score it competitively. Use it as a map, not a report card.

Part 1 — Early Literacy & Language (8)

- ☐ Recognizes most uppercase and lowercase letters by name
- ☐ Knows the sounds of at least 10–15 letters (sounds, not just names)
- ☐ Can identify the first sound in a spoken word (e.g., "dog" starts with /d/)
- ☐ Can rhyme words (cat/hat, dog/log) — or recognize when two words rhyme
- ☐ Knows that books are read left-to-right, top-to-bottom
- ☐ Can retell a simple story with a beginning, middle, and end
- ☐ Uses 4–6 word sentences to communicate thoughts and needs
- ☐ Can listen to a 5–10 minute read-aloud without major distraction

Part 2 — Number Sense & Early Math (5)

- ☐ Counts to 20 verbally, without skipping numbers
- ☐ Counts 10 objects with one-to-one correspondence (touches each)
- ☐ Recognizes written numerals 0 through 10
- ☐ Understands "more" and "less" with small groups of objects
- ☐ Recognizes basic shapes: circle, square, triangle, rectangle

Part 3 — Fine Motor & Pre-Writing (4)

- ☐ Holds a pencil or crayon with a functional grip
- ☐ Can write their first name (even if wobbly)
- ☐ Can trace basic lines, curves, and simple shapes
- ☐ Uses scissors to cut along a straight line

Part 4 — Social & Emotional Readiness (5)

- ☐ Can follow 2-step directions without needing them repeated
- ☐ Takes turns and plays cooperatively with other children

- ☐ Can handle frustration without a full meltdown (most of the time)
- ☐ Can ask for help using words
- ☐ Separates from a caregiver with manageable anxiety

Part 5 — Attention & Independence (3)

- ☐ Can stay on a single task for at least 10–15 minutes
- ☐ Manages basic self-care: bathroom, hand-washing, opening a lunchbox
- ☐ Shows curiosity — asks questions, wants to know how things work

How to read your results

20–25 checks: Strong shape. Keep reading together daily, playing counting/letter games, and building vocabulary through conversation. Consider readiness tutoring to sharpen any remaining gaps before August.

12–19 checks: A solid foundation with clear areas to strengthen. This is exactly the window where 2–3 months of targeted work makes a meaningful difference before kindergarten begins.

Under 12 checks: Don't panic — but start now. There's meaningful work to be done, and the earlier we begin, the more gradual and confident the progress.

The one thing that matters more than the score

Does your child want to learn? Are they curious? Do they try when something is hard? A child who walks in with genuine curiosity — even with gaps above — has something very hard to teach. Nurture that above everything else.

Want to talk through what you found?

Every family starts with a free 15-minute conversation — no pressure, just a plan built around your child.

Call or text Leslie: (615) 592-6584

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